people's army, but its handling of the Palestinian population is often brutal, particularly in the almost daily antiterrorist operations. It may be contributing to the noticeable brutalization of Israeli society. Yet in its firm stance against Smotrich and Ben-Gvir, it has created a further difficulty for Netanyahu's coalition, which is all to the good.

What I just wrote about the army is incorrect, if left at that: in an army that is among the most modern in the world, some of the infantry units ("Netzah Yehuda," among others) have, on occasion, brutalized the Palestinian population, sounding the alarm among Israeli and international human rights organizations. There is no doubt that this happens, but, do not let us forget, it happens in the context of heightened terrorist militancy instigated by Hamas and Islamic Jihad in the West Bank, and by Hezbollah in the north. Under such conditions, maintaining a thoroughly correct attitude is nearly impossible. Israel's problem is not the army as such but the decades-long occupation of the conquered territories.

As for the Israeli religious parties of today, they are both nationalist and ultra-Orthodox. Liberal Judaism never thrived in Israel. From the outset, Ben-Gurion, quite agnostic himself, accepted an arrangement whereby the religious aspects of private life (circumcision, bar mitzvah, marriage, divorce, funeral) would be enacted according to the rules of Orthodox Judaism. And, most importantly, at some later stage, the Knesset (the Israeli parliament) decided that the definition of who was a Jew would also depend on strict orthodoxy: a Jew who was born of a Jewish mother. This was essential for deciding who was entitled to citizenship and the benefits of the Law of Return. Conversions were considered valid only if performed by Orthodox rabbis. Over the decades, Conservative and Reform Judaism made some inroads, but only marginally so. In the meantime, relatively moderate Orthodox Jews (Mafdal, or National Religious Party) slowly dwindled. As for the ultra-Orthodox, also called Haredim, they are in a bizarre situation, as they do not recognize the State of Israel but have their